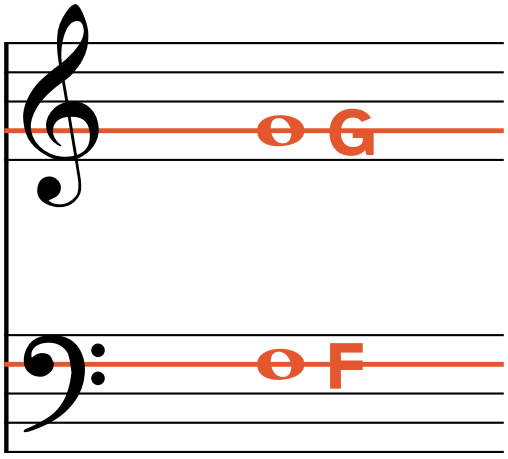
PART I · PITCH · 2

The staff and the clefs

Music is written on a **staff**: five lines and four spaces, counted from the **bottom**. Higher on the staff means higher on the keyboard. The **clef** at the start is the key to the code: it names one line, and every other note follows from it.

THE SECRET

The treble clef curls round G; the bass clef's two dots hug F.





Treble clef
curls round line 2: G

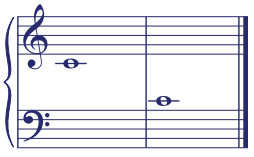


Bass clef
its dots hug line 4: F

Look closely: the treble clef curls round G · the bass clef's dots hug F

The grand staff

Piano music uses two staves joined by a brace: the **treble** staff on top, usually for the right hand, and the **bass** staff below, usually for the left. **Middle C** sits between them on a short line of its own, and can be written in either staff.

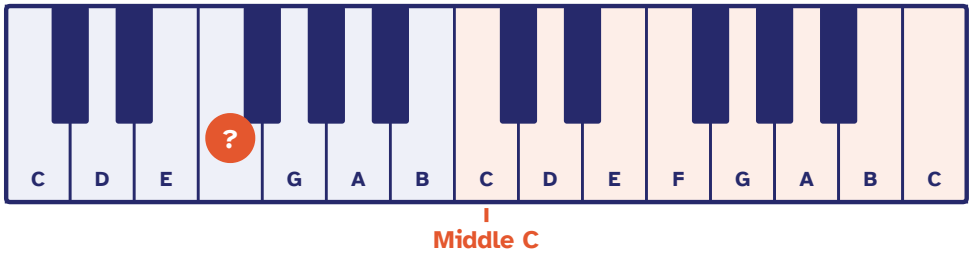


Middle C in the treble staff (left) and in the bass staff (right): the same key.

PART I · PITCH · 2 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE

Which staff is this key written on?



1. **Find Middle C.**
2. **Is the ? to its left or right?** Left is lower: the blue half.
3. **Low keys go on the bass staff**, high keys on the treble staff.

The **?** is below Middle C, so it is written on the **bass staff**, usually for the left hand.

GAME

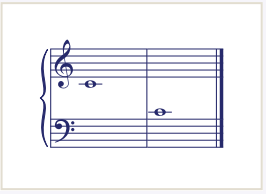
Treble or bass?

1. the E above Middle C
2. the lowest key on the piano
3. Middle C
4. High C

Which staff would each note be written on?

Answer: 1 treble · 2 bass · 3 either: it sits between the two · 4 treble.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Point, then play.

Point to the line the treble clef curls round and play that G. Point to the line between the bass clef's dots and play that F. Middle C sits between them.

YOU KNOW THIS

Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star



The treble clef curls round **line 2: G**, the very note Twinkle leaps up to.

Try it. Point to the G line, then play C C G G A A G.

THINK OF IT A clef is a pair of glasses: the same five lines read as different notes, depending on which pair you put on.

TRAP

× Reading bass-clef notes as if they were treble: check the clef on every line.

SEE ALSO

The staff and the keyboard p. 29 · Reading the notes p. 32

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Pitch 2 · Online: The Staff & the Two Clefs